countries, including India, to reduce oil imports from Iran to zero. Indian companies will be facing sanctions if India fails to comply. The Trump administration has taken a maximalist position on Iran, and it is willing to brook no dissent in the matter. India's defence ties with Russia are another point of contention. Per the US law called "Countering America's Adversaries Through Sanctions Act" (CAATSA), sanctions can be imposed on countries that engage in "significant transactions" with any of the listed 39 Russian companies. One Indian purchase that falls in this category is the S-400 Triumf air defence system. India has close defence ties with Russia, and Indian armed forces remain highly dependent on Russia, from cooperation on strategic technologies to supply of spares, maintenance repair, and overhaul.

Trade is the third leg of this triad that is generating tension, with the Trump administration pushing New Delhi to lower its trade barriers. Trump has accused India (along with other major economies) of charging 100 percent tariffs on some American goods, threatening to cut trade ties with them. India retaliated with its own tariffs on US products, in response to the US move to unilaterally raise import duties on Indian steel and aluminium – an issue that did not find resolution even during Trump's successful state visit to India in February 2020.

While the Trump administration's transactional approach has indeed generated some turbulence in the Indo–US relationship, New Delhi has managed to confidently bear this out as the fundamentals of the relationship continue to remain strong. Even critics of Modi's foreign policy testify to a new energy in the Indo–US bilateral relationship. What explains Modi's push towards this recalibration in Indo–US relations?

One reason behind this growing strategic embrace can be traced to the level of individual conviction. For Modi's vision of India's radical transformation, America remains essential. From "Make in India" to "Digital India," the success of Modi's